CHAPTER X

The Burden of Knowing Too Much

Kolkata · November–December 2023

> *“There are things we learn about another person that bring us no closer to understanding them. A name mentioned in passing, an absence that becomes familiar, a small change in the distance between two people—each seems insignificant until the mind begins to gather them into a meaning of its own. We mistake our attentiveness for understanding, forgetting how much of another life remains beyond our sight. And sometimes, what troubles us most is not what we have discovered, but the possibility that something precious has been changing quietly beside us, long before we learned to notice.”*

By the second half of November, Utkarsh had discovered that the Delhi Sultanate, besides its considerable contribution to Indian history, had also provided Ujjawal with an opportunity to demonstrate the full range of his vocal abilities.

The discovery was accidental.

Sanondita had missed a class, and Ujjawal, with the dependable generosity he appeared to reserve for her academic difficulties, had sent her photographs of his notes. Some of the abbreviations were difficult to follow. Rather than leave her to decipher them, he had supplied an explanation in the form of a WhatsApp voice message.

They were in one of the coaching centre’s classrooms with benches, rather than the separate chairs with writing tablets. Sanondita was sitting beside Utkarsh when she played it, their notebooks open on the desk in front of them.

“MBT,” Ujjawal began, in a voice of unexpected gravity, “means Muhammad bin Tughlaq.”

There was a pause.

“And GST means Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq.”

Another pause followed, this one accompanied by a small laugh whose purpose was not immediately apparent.

Utkarsh looked up from his notebook.

“Play that again.”

“Why?”

“I think I missed something.”

She moved the phone closer, and the message began once more.

Utkarsh listened carefully. He knew Ujjawal’s voice well enough. They had spoken in class, exchanged the usual complaints about examinations, and occasionally discussed questions neither of them could solve. Ujjawal ordinarily spoke in a perfectly unremarkable voice, neither especially deep nor particularly commanding.

The person explaining the Tughlaq dynasty, however, seemed to have undergone a remarkable transformation.

“Is he unwell?” Utkarsh asked.

Sanondita looked at him. “What?”

“His voice.”

“What about it?”

“Nothing. I’m just wondering whether he’s explaining history or recording a documentary.”

She laughed.

“No, seriously,” he continued. “I’ve heard him speak. Since when does he sound like this?”

“Like what?”

Utkarsh lowered his voice considerably.

“Muhammad bin Tughlaq.”

“Stop it!”

“I haven’t said anything.”

“You’ve been making fun of him for the last five minutes.”

“I’m appreciating his dedication. There’s a difference.”

Sanondita shook her head, still smiling, and returned her attention to the notes. Utkarsh, however, had developed a sudden and entirely unnecessary interest in the recording.

“Play the laughing part once more.”

“No.”

“Just that part.”

“Why?”

“For research.”

“What research?”

“I’m trying to understand what was so funny about Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq.”

She laughed again, louder this time, and turned the phone away from him.

“You’re impossible.”

“I’m serious. The man has been dead for nearly seven hundred years. Someone should tell him he’s still entertaining people.”

“Will you let me study?”

“Of course.”

He bent over his notebook with an expression of exemplary obedience. It lasted approximately twelve seconds.

“Although,” he said, without looking up, “I have one question.”

“I know it’s about Ujjawal.”

He looked up. She was already waiting for it.

“Does he send these historical performances to everyone, or are you receiving an exclusive subscription?”

Sanondita gave him a look that should have discouraged further investigation. Unfortunately, Utkarsh had never been particularly good at recognising when an investigation had become unnecessary.

“He was only explaining the abbreviations,” she said.

“Exactly. A generous man. Most people would simply type the full names. He has chosen to preserve the oral tradition.”

This time she tried not to laugh. Utkarsh watched her press her lips together, and the effort pleased him more than the joke itself.

“Don’t be mean,” she said at last.

“I’m not being mean.”

“You are.”

“Fine. I’ll apologise to him.”

“You’d better not message him.”

“Why would I message him?”

“Because I know you.”

He looked offended.

“Sanondita, I have a great deal of respect for a man who can make Muhammad bin Tughlaq sound mysterious.”

She gave up trying to suppress her laughter.

For a little while, that was all there was to it: a phone lying between two notebooks, an unfinished page of history, and the particular pleasure of making someone laugh when she was trying very hard not to.

It was one of the things Utkarsh liked most about sitting beside her. Their conversations rarely required an occasion. A difficult question, a teacher’s peculiar expression, an unfortunate spelling mistake—almost anything could become a subject of discussion. Sometimes they returned to their books within a minute. Sometimes an entire break disappeared before either noticed.

Ujjawal, meanwhile, remained a familiar figure across the classroom, usually somewhere in the right-hand column. He rarely spoke to Sanondita there. Whatever conversations they had seemed to take place more comfortably through WhatsApp, where he could send notes, explanations, and, occasionally, invitations to go somewhere together.

Those invitations had become another source of amusement.

Sanondita had mentioned more than once that Ujjawal wanted to take her out. Not on a date, at least not in the way he presented it. He would suggest going somewhere as friends, and she would find some reason not to.

Utkarsh had heard several of those reasons. They were not always especially convincing.

“You should maintain a register,” he told her one afternoon.

“For what?”

“Your excuses. Otherwise, one day you’ll forget which one you’ve already used.”

“I don’t make excuses.”

“Of course not. You just happen to be extraordinarily busy whenever Ujjawal wants to go somewhere.”

“I am busy.”

“Yes. A woman of great responsibilities.”

She rolled her eyes.

“Why are you so interested in whether I go out with him?”

“I’m concerned about his academic future. He spends so much time explaining history to you that he may forget to study it himself.”

“He studies more than you do.”

The remark arrived so promptly that Utkarsh had no opportunity to prepare a defence.

He looked at her.

“That was unnecessary.”

“It’s true.”

“Truth is not an excuse for cruelty.”

She laughed, satisfied with the result, and returned to her notebook.

Utkarsh pretended to be wounded. In fact, he was rather pleased. She had become increasingly comfortable answering his teasing with remarks of her own, and he enjoyed those small defeats almost as much as his victories.

He did not think much about Ujjawal’s invitations then. Or, at least, he did not think about them in any way that disturbed his amusement.

Ujjawal liked her. That much seemed obvious to Utkarsh, though the invitations themselves were always offered in the ordinary language of friendship. Sanondita appeared to understand his interest without wishing to discuss it seriously. She declined his

suggestions, accepted his notes when they were useful, and continued speaking to him.

There was nothing especially remarkable about any of it.

Yet Utkarsh sometimes found himself looking towards the right-hand column after one of their conversations had ended.

He wondered whether Ujjawal ever noticed how easily Sanondita laughed beside him.

Perhaps he did. Perhaps he was too occupied with the lesson to care. Utkarsh had no reason to assume that a boy sitting across the room spent his afternoons observing them.

Still, the thought occurred to him.

And because it was not yet an uncomfortable thought, he allowed himself a small, private satisfaction.

Sanondita could receive a dozen explanations of medieval history on WhatsApp.

But when something amused her in the classroom, it was often Utkarsh who heard her laugh first.

It was only later, on an afternoon when the class had ended earlier than expected, that Utkarsh began to find something peculiar about Ujjawal's persistence.

Sanondita was putting her books into her bag when her phone lit up. She glanced at the screen, gave a small, disbelieving smile, and continued arranging her things.

"What happened?" Utkarsh asked.

"Nothing."

"That looked like a very specific kind of nothing."

She turned the phone face down.

"Ujjawal."

"Ah." Utkarsh nodded with the solemnity of a doctor receiving a familiar diagnosis. "The historian returns."

"Will you stop calling him that?"

"Certainly. What does His Majesty want?"

"He's asking whether I'll go somewhere with him this weekend."

Utkarsh looked towards the right-hand column. Ujjawal's usual seat was empty; he had already left.

"Again?"

"Hmm."

"Remarkable. The man has survived more refusals than the Tughlaq dynasty survived rebellions."

"You don't even know how many rebellions there were."

"Neither did they, apparently. That was part of the problem."

Sanondita laughed and slipped her phone into her bag.

"So? Are you going?"

"No."

"Why?"

"I have things to do."

"What things?"

"Things."

"An impressively detailed schedule."

She gave him a warning look.

Utkarsh raised both hands. "All right. I withdraw the question."

He reached for his bag. She had stopped smiling at the question, and he had no wish to make her repeat herself. There was still a page sticking out of his notebook; he tucked it in while she finished packing.

They left the classroom together, joining the familiar movement of students towards the staircase. For a while, their conversation wandered elsewhere—to a question the teacher had solved too quickly, to an upcoming examination, to a classmate whose confidence had exceeded his accuracy by a considerable margin.

Utkarsh was still smiling when a thought interrupted him.

Ujjawal had asked her to go somewhere.

There was nothing extraordinary about it. Friends invited one another out all the time. Sanondita had refused, and Ujjawal would presumably find something else to do with his weekend.

Yet Utkarsh could not remember the last time he had allowed himself to make a similar suggestion.

It was not that he lacked the words. He could imagine asking her to visit a bookshop, have something to eat after class, or walk a little farther before they parted. He had spoken to her about more complicated things without difficulty.

The difficulty lay in what those ordinary words would mean to him.

For Ujjawal, an invitation could remain an invitation, at least in the form in which he offered it. Utkarsh could not be certain what Ujjawal privately hoped for, but he seemed willing to ask without allowing that uncertainty to silence him.

Utkarsh knew what he himself would be hoping for.

He would remember the afternoon long afterward. He would notice how much time she had given him, whether she seemed happy, whether she had been the first to suggest leaving. He would carry home details she might have forgotten before reaching her own door.

And somewhere behind all those imagined details stood Nayan.

A name, a photograph, an outing, an answer that had settled nothing.

Utkarsh had never learned whether Nayan was Sanondita's boyfriend. The birthday photographs had settled nothing. Still, whenever he imagined asking her somewhere, he found himself allowing for an answer she had never given him.

Perhaps Ujjawal knew about Nayan too. Perhaps he didn't. Utkarsh had never asked him.

He wondered what it would be like to know less.

He nearly asked her then. The beginning of the sentence was ready: after class, one day, if she had time. He could already hear how many ways he would offer her to refuse before she had even answered.

Still, Utkarsh could not make the invitation feel innocent inside his own mind.

He had spent months choosing what to say and what to leave alone. He could tease her about almost anything, but a simple

invitation remained difficult. Sometimes he called that consideration. On the stairs beside her, he could no longer quite separate it from fear.

He watched her turn towards the next flight, still talking, unaware of the sentence he had abandoned.

Ujjawal, with his unusually deep voice and his repeated invitations, had somehow made those choices visible.

"Are you listening?"

Utkarsh turned.

Sanondita was standing a step below him, looking back.

"Yes."

"What did I say?"

He considered his options.

"Something important."

"Utkarsh."

"Extremely important."

She shook her head.

"You weren't listening."

"I was thinking."

"About what?"

He glanced towards the staircase ahead.

"Whether Muhammad bin Tughlaq would have been more successful if he'd used WhatsApp."

For a moment she only stared at him. Then she laughed, shaking her head as she continued downstairs.

Utkarsh followed, grateful for the ease with which he could still make her laugh.

He had answered her question without telling her anything.

It was a skill he had become rather good at.

He was beginning to wonder what it had cost him.

The days that followed offered Utkarsh little reason to believe that anything had changed.

There were classes, questions, unfinished notes, and the familiar disappointment of discovering that a topic understood perfectly well during a lecture had become almost unrecognisable by the time he attempted it alone. Some afternoons Sanondita arrived before him; on others, he found her usual place empty and learned, either from a message or from the simple fact of her absence, that she would not be attending.

She had missed classes before. There was nothing new in that.

Her attendance had been unpredictable for weeks. Lately, he had begun noticing how much of his own afternoon depended on whether she came.

He had once grown accustomed to finding her there. Not with the certainty of an arrangement— neither of them had ever made one—but with the quiet confidence that develops when something pleasant happens often enough to seem ordinary.

Now he sometimes entered the classroom and looked towards their usual seats before remembering that she might not come.

He disliked this small habit of looking.

It made his expectations visible to himself.

On the days she attended, however, there was usually enough familiarity to make such thoughts seem unnecessary.

She still asked him about questions she found difficult. She still disagreed with his explanations when she suspected he had skipped a step, and she remained perfectly capable of reminding him that his confidence in mathematics occasionally exceeded his accuracy.

Once, after he had spent several minutes explaining a problem, she examined his answer and pointed towards the second line.

“You’ve written the wrong sign.”

Utkarsh looked down.

He had.

“That’s a minor technical issue.”

“Your whole answer is wrong.”

“Only because the examiner insists on following the rules.”

“Obviously.”

“A very narrow-minded profession, examining.”

She laughed and pushed the notebook back towards him.

He corrected the sign, continued the calculation, and discovered that the answer now agreed with the one printed in the book.

“There,” he said. “A difference of opinion resolved.”

“You made a mistake.”

“I prefer to think of it as giving you an opportunity to participate.”

“Then thank you.”

“You’re welcome.”

Such conversations could make an afternoon feel unchanged.

And perhaps, in the ways that mattered to Sanondita, it was unchanged. Utkarsh had no reason to assume that every small variation in her behaviour belonged to a larger story.

He knew she had responsibilities beyond coaching. She taught students herself, had her own family and friends, and lived most of her days in places where he was not present. He had understood this long before November, although understanding it had never entirely prevented him from wondering about the hours he knew nothing of.

He did not ask why she missed so many classes.

Sometimes he wanted to. Sometimes a perfectly ordinary question—Are you coming tomorrow?— remained unwritten on his phone because he disliked how eagerly he was waiting for the answer.

He would put the phone aside and return to his books.

There were examinations to prepare for, and he was already losing more time than he could afford.

On an afternoon when Sanondita was absent, he found himself sitting alone in their usual place. The teacher had begun discussing a topic Utkarsh had intended to revise the previous evening. He opened his notebook, wrote down the heading, and tried to follow the explanation.

After several minutes, he realised he had copied a line incorrectly.

He crossed it out.

A little later, he found himself looking at the empty space beside him.

He looked away almost at once.

It was absurd, he thought, to have become so accustomed to another person’s presence that an ordinary classroom bench could appear incomplete.

The bench was not incomplete. It had room for two people, and only one had come.

He returned to the lesson.

By the time the teacher moved to the next question, Utkarsh had begun paying attention again.

There were still afternoons when he studied well, answered questions confidently, and went home satisfied with the work he had completed. On those days he could tell exactly where his hours had gone. He liked opening his notebook later and finding something finished, something he would not have to begin again tomorrow.

His ambitions had existed before he met her. They had brought him to Kolkata, into these classrooms, and towards a future he had spent years imagining. Whatever he felt for Sanondita, he did not want to become someone who remembered his own plans only when she was absent.

And yet her absence made concentration easier in one respect and harder in another.

When she was beside him, he sometimes became distracted by conversation.

When she was not, he occasionally found himself waiting for one.

It was a thoroughly inconvenient arrangement, and he suspected that no examination syllabus had been designed to account for it.

He smiled faintly at the thought.

Then he turned the page.

The first changes in the distance between them were less noticeable than her absences.

They happened on days when she was there.

Utkarsh had always been conscious of how they sat together. From the beginning, he had maintained a little space between them, careful with his elbows and the movement of his arms, unwilling to allow an accidental touch to become something she might find uncomfortable.

Over time, the habit had become almost unconscious.

He moved his belongings when she needed room. He kept his notebook within his own portion of the desk. When they leaned towards the same page, he adjusted his position without thinking much about it.

These were small things, hardly worth remembering.

And because he was so accustomed to making those adjustments himself, he did not immediately notice when Sanondita sometimes seemed to make them first.

There was no particular afternoon on which the change announced itself.

No conversation stopped abruptly. No disagreement explained it. She did not tell him that he was sitting too close. He had tried to be careful; he could not know whether she had always felt as comfortable as he hoped.

She simply appeared, on certain days, a little more conscious of the space between them.

At first, Utkarsh attached no meaning to it.

People shifted in their seats. They moved notebooks, adjusted bags, and leaned away from crowded desks for reasons that had nothing to do with the person beside them.

He knew this.

And because he knew it, he continued doing what he had always done.

He listened when she spoke. He teased her when the opportunity presented itself. He helped with questions he understood and occasionally pretended to understand those he didn't.

She laughed at some of his jokes.

She ignored others.

In that respect, at least, their friendship remained reassuringly familiar.

When he remembered those afternoons, it was usually something she had said that returned first. Her movements remained somewhere at the edge of the conversation, too ordinary to hold his attention for long.

The recognition came without the courtesy of an occasion.

It was an ordinary afternoon, late enough in the year for the sunlight to have begun withdrawing from the classroom before the lesson was over. The windows remained open, though the air had grown cooler, and the teacher was working through a question whose solution occupied most of the board.

Sanondita had arrived shortly before class began.

Utkarsh had been there for several minutes already, an unusual achievement he might ordinarily have considered worth announcing. She had taken her familiar seat beside him, placed her bag down, and asked whether the teacher had said anything important.

"Nothing you can't recover from," he told her.

"So nothing important?"

"I wouldn't go that far. My presence has improved the academic atmosphere considerably."

She glanced at the notebook in front of him.

"You haven't even written the date."

"I was waiting for inspiration."

"Try looking at the calendar."

He smiled and wrote it down.

For the first part of the lesson, nothing seemed different. They followed the explanation, occasionally exchanged a quiet question,

and returned to their notebooks whenever the teacher looked towards their side of the room.

Then Sanondita leaned forward to see a line on the board.

Her bag shifted slightly against the desk. She drew it closer to herself, moved her notebook with it, and settled back into her seat.

Utkarsh noticed the movement only because he had been about to move his own notebook to give her more room.

His hand stopped.

There was nothing unusual about what she had done. She was arranging her belongings. People did that throughout the day, usually without anyone considering it worthy of attention.

He lowered his hand and returned to the question.

A few minutes later, she adjusted her position again, leaving a little more space between their arms.

This time he noticed.

Not because the movement was large. It wasn't. Nor because she seemed uncomfortable. She continued following the lesson with the same concentration as before.

What struck him was the faint familiarity of the gesture.

He had made movements like that himself.

For months.

He had shifted his elbows, drawn his books towards him, and adjusted the way he sat whenever their arms came too close. He had done it so often that the movement no longer required a decision.

And now he was watching Sanondita do something that looked remarkably similar.

He tried to dismiss the thought.

For a moment, he remembered the sentence he had folded beside the perfume. She had thanked him for the gift. They had never spoken about the note.

He glanced at her, then back at his page. Had he begun watching her more closely since he gave it to her? He could not tell when her movements had changed, or when he had started expecting them to

mean something. The teacher was still explaining the question. He had missed another step.

Nevertheless, he became conscious of the space between them.

That was the first difficulty.

Once he had noticed it, he could no longer sit without noticing it again.

He became aware of where his arm rested, how far her notebook extended across the desk, and whether the space between their shoulders was greater than it had been a few weeks earlier.

He could not remember.

That was the second difficulty.

He remembered the afternoon she had first sat beside him. He remembered their conversations, the small disagreements, the occasions when she had laughed at something he had said. He could recall the rain beneath the umbrella, the narrow shelter they had shared, and the care he had taken to keep it tilted towards her.

Yet he could not have said how far apart their elbows had been on any ordinary November afternoon.

He had never thought to remember such a thing.

The teacher finished the question and asked whether anyone had obtained a different answer.

Sanondita looked towards Utkarsh's notebook.

"What did you get?"

He glanced down.

He had written the first two steps correctly. After that, his work ended.

"I'm still considering the possibilities."

She looked at the unfinished calculation.

"You haven't solved it."

"That's one possibility."

She gave him an amused look.

"Then what have you been doing?"

"Thinking."

"About the question?"

He hesitated.

“Not successfully.”

She laughed softly and turned back towards the board.

He smiled because she had smiled, and because their familiar exchanges still pleased him. Whatever else he had begun noticing, he did not want to forget that she was sitting beside him, speaking to him as she always had.

But his attention did not settle.

He looked towards the teacher, copied the next line, and tried to follow the explanation. After a while, he found himself wondering whether Sanondita had been making these small adjustments for several days.

Or several weeks.

Had she begun sitting a little farther away before her attendance became irregular? Had he failed to notice because he had been too occupied with his own efforts to maintain the same distance?

Perhaps there had been no change at all.

Perhaps the space had always been there, and he was noticing it only because he had begun looking for things that might explain his uncertainty.

That possibility was reasonable.

It was also strangely difficult to accept.

He had once believed that the little distance between them was something he maintained himself. Not because she had asked him to, but because he wanted her to feel entirely at ease beside him.

He had made those adjustments without mentioning them. Now he was trying to remember hers, reaching back through afternoons he had thought he knew by heart. The more carefully he searched, the less certain the details became.

Now he wondered whether she had been equally conscious of the space all along.

The thought embarrassed him.

He drew his notebook towards him, then stopped. Moving it farther would make no difference to her comfort; there was already room. He had only wanted to be the one who moved first.

That was harder to admit than the disappointment itself.

At the end of the lesson, Sanondita closed her notebook and began putting away her things.

“Did you understand the last question?” she asked.

“Mostly.”

“Can you explain it to me later?”

“Of course.”

She nodded and continued packing.

It was an ordinary request. She had made similar requests before, and he had answered them in much the same way.

For a moment, he felt foolish for having spent so much of the afternoon troubled by the distance between two people who were still comfortable enough to ask one another for help.

He began putting away his own books.

Sanondita stood, adjusted the strap of her bag, and waited while he finished.

That, too, was familiar.

He looked at her and smiled.

“Next time, remind me to solve the question before offering to explain it.”

“That’s usually how studying works.”

“I’ve been experimenting with alternatives.”

“Clearly.”

They left the classroom together.

Utkarsh followed her towards the staircase, listening as she began telling him something about another lesson. He answered when she expected an answer, made a joke when the opportunity arose, and gradually found himself enjoying the conversation.

By the time they reached the ground floor, he had almost forgotten what had troubled him.

Almost.

Later, on the journey home, he tried to remember when Sanondita had first begun sitting that way.

He could not.

What unsettled him was not that she had moved a little farther away.

It was the possibility that she had been doing so for some time, while he had continued believing the distance between them was entirely his own doing.

He had noticed every occasion on which she came closer. How many ordinary movements away had he simply failed to keep?

By the first week of December, Utkarsh had begun to distrust the conclusions he reached on his way home.

They arrived too easily.

An empty seat became an absence worth explaining. A conversation that ended sooner than expected became a sign of something. A small movement on a classroom bench, which he would once have forgotten before reaching the staircase, followed him through the evening with the persistence of an unfinished question.

He was aware of the absurdity. He was also aware that recognising an absurdity did not always make it disappear.

One afternoon, Sanondita forwarded him a set of notes from Ujjawal.

They had both missed the previous class, and Ujjawal had sent her photographs of everything the teacher had written. The pages were carefully arranged, the headings underlined, and the abbreviations explained wherever they might cause confusion.

Utkarsh examined them.

“He’s becoming dangerously efficient.”

Sanondita looked up from her phone.

“Who?”

“Ujjawal. At this rate, we’ll have no reason to attend classes.”

“Then you should thank him.”

“I will. Once I’ve verified that he hasn’t recorded an audiobook to accompany these.”

She smiled.

“He’s helping us.”

“I know.”

And he did know.

There was something almost touching about the care with which Ujjawal prepared his notes. Whatever hopes might accompany that care, the notes themselves were useful, and Utkarsh had benefited from them often enough to feel a little ashamed of how readily he made jokes at their sender’s expense.

He began copying a section he had missed.

Across the classroom, Ujjawal was speaking to another student. His ordinary voice carried just far enough for Utkarsh to recognise it.

Utkarsh glanced up.

For a moment he remembered the exaggerated gravity of the voice message and nearly smiled.

Then Sanondita said something about a question in the notes, and he turned towards her.

They spent several minutes discussing it. She disagreed with his method, he insisted that his method was perfectly respectable, and they eventually discovered that both had overlooked a condition printed beneath the question.

“Excellent,” Utkarsh said. “We’ve achieved equality.”

“In what?”

“Being wrong.”

“Speak for yourself. I was following your explanation.”

“An unfortunate decision. I hope you’ve learned from it.”

She laughed.

It was then, while he was still smiling, that he happened to look across the room again.

Ujjawal was sitting at his desk.

Utkarsh could not tell whether he had been watching them. By the time their eyes might have met, Ujjawal had lowered his head towards his notebook.

There was nothing to interpret.

Yet a thought came to Utkarsh with such unexpected clarity that he stopped smiling.

What if Ujjawal wondered about these afternoons?

What if he, too, remembered the smallest things—the way Sanondita laughed, the people she chose to sit beside, the conversations she seemed reluctant to end?

Perhaps Ujjawal had never given any of it a moment's consideration. Perhaps his interest in Sanondita was simpler than Utkarsh imagined. A boy could like a girl, invite her somewhere, be refused, and continue with his life without turning every exchange into a question about his place in hers.

But perhaps it was not so simple.

Utkarsh looked down at the notes Ujjawal had prepared.

The handwriting was neat. A few words had been crossed out and rewritten. There was a small arrow connecting an explanation to the line above it.

He wondered how long Ujjawal had spent making those pages readable.

He wondered whether Ujjawal had been pleased when Sanondita asked for them, or when she thanked him.

And then he wondered whether Ujjawal knew that she had forwarded the same notes to Utkarsh, who was now sitting beside her, enjoying the conversation Ujjawal could only imagine.

The thought made him uncomfortable.

Earlier, he would have found something to say about that thought—another joke about an exclusive subscription, perhaps. Now he looked at the small arrow on the page. Without it, he would have missed the explanation too.

Still, Utkarsh had sometimes taken a private satisfaction in being the person beside her.

He had enjoyed the thought that she laughed with him, that she asked him questions, that she waited while he packed his books.

He knew none of these things was a promise.

He had still returned to them whenever he needed reassurance.

Now, looking at Ujjawal's careful notes, he remembered the private satisfaction of hearing Sanondita laugh beside him. He had wondered whether Ujjawal noticed. He had rather hoped he did.

His pen rested against the page. Across the room, Ujjawal turned back to his work.

What troubled Utkarsh was the resemblance.

He had spent so much time imagining Nayan that he had almost forgotten what he might look like from another boy's place in the classroom.

To Ujjawal, perhaps, Utkarsh was the name that appeared too often in Sanondita's ordinary stories.

The boy who sat beside her.

The boy who made her laugh.

The boy who could ask whether she understood a question without needing to invent a reason for speaking to her.

Utkarsh knew how little those things proved.

He knew it because he possessed them, and they had proved so little to him.

He remembered asking Sanondita to play the laughing part again. At the time, all he had wanted was to make her laugh too. Now he could imagine Ujjawal listening to his own message before sending it, wondering whether he sounded foolish. He did not know whether that had happened. He knew what it would feel like.

Perhaps there was a whole private life behind those messages.

Perhaps there wasn't.

Utkarsh had no way of knowing.

He looked at Sanondita. She was writing something in the margin of her notebook, occasionally checking the page Ujjawal had sent.

She was checking an answer, her pen moving between the margin and the question. Whatever she knew of either boy's feelings, she was occupied now with the work in front of her. Utkarsh found his own place on the page. He had barely copied half of it.

"What's wrong?" she asked.

"Nothing."

"You've been staring at that page."

"I'm appreciating the handwriting."

"Ujjawal's?"

"Yes. Very disciplined. Mine looks like it was written during an earthquake."

She leaned towards his notebook.

"That's actually true."

"Thank you for your support."

"You're welcome."

He smiled, and she returned to her work.

During the next break, Utkarsh crossed to Ujjawal's desk.

"Sanondita sent me your notes," he said. "That explanation in the margin helped. Thanks."

Ujjawal looked up. "You understood it?"

"Yes."

"Good."

Utkarsh stood there a moment longer. He had expected to feel awkward; Ujjawal had already moved his book to show another student a question. Utkarsh returned to his seat.

Then the thought of Nayan returned.

Utkarsh knew almost nothing about the place Nayan occupied in Sanondita's life. There had been photographs, outings, mentions of a friend. Enough to trouble him; never enough to settle anything.

He could imagine Sanondita laughing with Nayan as easily as he could remember her laughing beside him.

That was the cruelty of imagination. It required so little evidence and offered so much detail.

He could picture conversations he had never heard, journeys he had never taken, afternoons in which his name had no reason to arise. He could make them seem almost real simply by returning to them often enough.

Yet when he examined what he actually knew, there was very little.

He did not know what she felt for Nayan.

He did not know whether the changes he had noticed in class had anything to do with him.

He did not even know whether those changes existed outside his own increasingly watchful mind.

And still, he had begun arranging his days around the possibility of an answer.

He could leave a question unasked and spend the whole evening trying to answer it himself. He had called that leaving her alone. Yet here he was, scarcely listening to a lesson, searching for an explanation in the way she moved her notebook.

There were things she might never tell him. He would still have to sit beside her without knowing them.

He could accept that she might care for someone else. At least, he believed he could. What he found harder was the thought that she might do so without his ever knowing when it began, what it meant, or whether anything between them had changed because of it.

He wanted an explanation for a loss he could not establish had occurred.

The shame of that desire was quiet, but unmistakable.

He closed the notebook.

Sanondita looked at him.

“Finished?”

“Not even close.”

“Then why are you closing it?”

“I’m considering a different career.”

“What career?”

“One that doesn’t involve examinations.”

“Good luck finding one.”

He laughed, and this time the laughter came easily.

She smiled and returned to her notes.

Utkarsh opened his notebook again.

Across the room, Ujjawal was still working. Sanondita was beside him, writing in the margin of a page. Outside, the afternoon continued towards evening without offering anyone an explanation.

For a little while, Utkarsh tried to do the same.

He copied the next question, underlined the important words, and began solving it.

He had spent months wondering what Nayan might have that he did not.

Until that afternoon, it had scarcely occurred to him that Ujjawal might be wondering the same thing about him.

He could imagine an answer all too easily.

She sits beside you. She laughs with you. She waits for you.

He could have listed every small privilege.

He could not have explained why none of them had ever been enough to quiet his own heart.

Towards the middle of December, Utkarsh arrived at coaching a few minutes later than usual.

The class had not begun, but most of the seats were occupied. Students were talking across the narrow aisles, exchanging questions and complaints about examinations, while someone near the front was trying unsuccessfully to convince a friend that the answer printed in the book was wrong.

Utkarsh entered with his bag slipping from one shoulder.

He looked towards the left-hand column.

Sanondita was there.

She had not attended the previous class, and he had not known whether she would come that afternoon. For a moment, the sight of her was enough to interrupt the thoughts he had carried through the day.

She looked up as he approached.

“You’re late.”

“The teacher hasn’t arrived.”

“That doesn’t mean you’re not late.”

“I see you’ve started teaching punctuality now.”

“Someone has to.”

He smiled.

Her bag was resting on the bench beside her. As he came closer, she lifted it and placed it near her feet.

There was room for him.

It was such an ordinary gesture that he would once have accepted it without a second thought. He had seen her do it before. He had done the same for her.

Yet for an instant he remained standing, his hand still holding the strap of his bag.

“Are you going to sit,” she asked, “or have you come to inspect the furniture?”

“I’m considering whether this bench meets the required standards.”

“And?”

“Questionable construction. Excellent company.”

She rolled her eyes.

“Sit down.”

He did.

The teacher arrived shortly afterward, carrying a stack of papers and an expression that suggested the class was already behind schedule. Conversations stopped, notebooks opened, and the afternoon settled into its familiar rhythm.

Utkarsh tried to pay attention.

For a while, he succeeded.

Sanondita was beside him, copying from the board. Once, when the teacher turned away, she leaned towards Utkarsh’s notebook to check a step she had missed. He tilted the page so she could see it more clearly.

“Your handwriting is getting worse,” she whispered.

“It’s becoming more advanced.”

“Advanced?”

“Only serious students can read it.”

“Then you must be the only serious student here.”

He lowered his voice.

“Even I struggle sometimes.”

She laughed under her breath and returned to her own page.

Utkarsh looked towards the board, smiling.

Nothing had happened.

That was what made the afternoon difficult to understand.

Nothing had happened, and he was happy.

Nothing had happened, and he was afraid of losing something.

He had spent so many evenings trying to interpret Sanondita’s absences, her changing habits, the small distance he thought he had begun to notice between them. Yet here she was, making fun of his handwriting, asking for his help, leaving room for him on the bench.

If he had been asked to explain what was wrong, he would have struggled to answer.

Perhaps nothing was wrong.

Perhaps the only thing changing was his ability to enjoy what had once been enough.

The thought stayed with him through the lesson.

At one point, Sanondita reached for her bag and shifted slightly to retrieve a pen. Utkarsh moved his elbow to give her room. When she sat upright again, there was a little space between them.

He noticed it.

Of course he noticed it.

But this time he also remembered how she had moved her bag when he arrived.

He could not make one gesture cancel the other. Nor could he make either of them mean more than it did.

She had made room for him.

She had also made room for herself.

There was no contradiction in that.

It was only his heart that seemed determined to find one.

When the class ended, the room filled with footsteps and the sound of bags being zipped. Sanondita was still finishing a line in her notebook, and Utkarsh waited while she wrote.

“Done?” he asked.

“One minute.”

“You’ve been saying that for five.”

“Then you should know by now what it means.”

He laughed.

She finished the sentence, closed her notebook, and began packing.

For a moment he considered asking whether she would attend the next class.

It was an innocent question. He had asked it before, and she had asked him the same. There was no reason to treat it as a confession.

Still, he knew what he would do with her answer.

If she said yes, he would look forward to seeing her.

If she said no, he would wonder what she was doing instead.

If she said she wasn’t sure, he would carry that uncertainty home and turn it over until it began to resemble a problem he ought to be able to solve.

He was tired of doing that.

So he helped her gather a loose sheet that had slipped from her notebook, handed it back, and said nothing about the next class.

“Thank you,” she said.

“Careful. You’ll ruin my reputation.”

“What reputation?”

He looked at her.

“That was unnecessarily quick.”

She laughed, and they left together.

Outside, the December air had grown cooler. The light was fading from the buildings, and people were moving past them with the purposeful impatience of an evening in Kolkata.

They walked towards the place where they usually parted.

Sanondita spoke about a question she wanted to practise before the next examination. Utkarsh suggested a method, she pointed out that it sounded unnecessarily complicated, and he admitted that he had not yet tried it himself.

“So you’re giving me advice you haven’t followed?” she asked.

“I’m saving you the trouble of discovering my mistakes.”

“How generous.”

“I try.”

Their conversation continued easily.

He could still do this, he realised. He could walk beside her and listen. He could enjoy her company without searching every word for reassurance. For several minutes at a time, he could even forget the questions that had made the past few weeks so exhausting.

The knowledge should have comforted him.

In a way, it did.

They reached the point where their routes separated.

Sanondita adjusted her bag and looked at him.

“All right, I’ll go.”

“Okay.”

“Send me that question when you get home.”

“I will.”

“And make sure the answer is correct this time.”

“I can’t promise miracles.”

She smiled.

“Bye, Utkarsh.”

“Bye.”

She turned and walked away.

He stood for a moment, watching her join the people moving along the pavement.

There was nothing unusual in the goodbye. She had said his name, smiled, and asked him to send a question. She had given him no reason to believe she was unhappy with him.

He knew that.

He also knew that he could have asked her to stay a little longer. He could have suggested something to eat, or another walk, or simply a few more minutes of conversation.

She might have agreed.

She might have refused.

Neither answer would have been a judgment upon him, and neither would have told him what he wanted to know.

He watched until she passed behind a group of people at the crossing. Then he adjusted his bag. He had a question to send her when he got home; he tried to remember which page it was on.

Utkarsh started walking.

He thought of Ujjawal's careful notes, the invitations Sanondita had declined, and the strange tenderness he had felt upon imagining another boy's uncertainty.

He thought of Nayan, whose place in her life remained unknown to him.

And he thought of the afternoon he had just spent beside her.

It would have been easy to remember only what frightened him: the space between their arms, the classes she had missed, the possibility that some part of her life was moving farther beyond his reach.

But she had also moved her bag when he arrived.

She had laughed at his jokes.

She had asked him to send the question when he got home.

Those things were real, too.

He wished he knew how to keep them without asking them to become something else.

At home that evening, he found the question Sanondita had asked for. He checked the solution twice, took a photograph, and sent it to her.

A little later, she replied.

Thank you.

He looked at the message and smiled.

Then he put the phone down.

He opened his notebook. Before beginning the next question, he reached for the phone once more, then left it where it was. Her reply was still the same reply.

He wrote down the first step. There were evenings when he could do this easily; tonight he had to bring himself back to the page. He worked through another line, checked it, and went on.

Later, closing the book, he remembered standing beside her bench with his bag still on his shoulder. She had looked up, lifted her own bag, and waited for him to sit.

He could remember that without deciding what tomorrow would be like. For a moment, he managed it: her face turned towards him, the place she had cleared, his own foolish delay before sitting down.

Then he wanted to know whether she would be there again.

For she had never asked him to make a promise out of the place beside her.

She had only made room.